the next chapter.

The very detailed 1981 Resolution tries to maintain a careful balance between acknowledging and criticizing the major errors Mao was guilty of, but at the same time reaffirming his political and ideological leadership. His many ideological treatises, his writings on political and military strategy, are carefully reaffirmed, and they remain the source of political legitimacy for the Party. The oft-quoted ‘70 per cent positive and 30 per cent negative’ evaluation of Mao is not contained in the Resolution but has been ascribed to Deng, though the contents of the Resolution would suggest a less favourable assessment. The stark warning against the personality cult and the reaffirmation of collective leadership stands out when the Party is once again heading in the same dangerous direction under the current leader, Xi Jinping. Is this tendency to slip into a personality cult inherent in the lingering legacy of Chinese imperial culture, or is to be attributed to the nature of a Marxist–Leninist political state? Perhaps it is a bit of both.

The purpose of dwelling at some length on these two historical Resolutions is to be able to see China’s view of itself and of the world around it through its own distinctive lens. It draws upon China’s long-standing culture and traditions of statecraft, which however over the past 100 years has been overlaid by the dynamics of a Marxist–Leninist state. The constant quest to reconcile Marxism–Leninism with the practical reality of China runs through both the historical Resolutions, but we constantly observe how the impulses drawn from China’s long history and deeply ingrained culture seep through in both the idiom of statecraft and its practice. The practice of adding the phrase ‘with Chinese characteristics’ to virtually every policy line is a symptom of this.

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As mentioned earlier, we now have a third Historical Resolution under the aegis of Xi Jinping adopted by the Sixth Plenum of the Nineteenth Central Committee on 11 November 2021. It bears the stamp of Xi Jinping, just as the first Resolution reflected that of Mao and the second Resolution that of Deng Xiaoping. Understandably, there is no echo of Deng’s warning against